Practical Collaboration and Partnership

AI-Enhanced ESG Reporting for UK SMEs

Funded by **British Academy Mid-Career Fellowship (MCFSS25_250036)**

Overview

This research investigates how AI can support SMEs in adopting AI-enhanced ESG reporting to meet emerging regulatory requirements and supply chain demands. We welcome participants from practitioners, organizations, and participants to strengthen the empirical quality and real-world relevance of this work.

No financial cost required. All research is funded by the British Academy Fellowship.

How You Can Participate

1. SME Program

For: Small and Medium-Sized Enterprises

What you get:

- Free AI-generated ESG reports for your company across three frameworks (IFRS S1/S2, GRI Standards, VSME) provided by the research
- Feedback on report quality and how it compares to your current disclosures
- Access to research findings and insights
- Private reports: your data and reports remain completely confidential

What you provide:

- **Minimal time commitment:** Just your company registration number
- **Optional:** Additional company information (e.g., governance, strategic initiatives, workforce data) if you wish to enrich the reports
- **Surveys & feedback:** Share your perspective on report usefulness (10-20 minutes)
- **Optional interviews:** Discuss your experience with the AI reports (20-30 minutes, optional)

No AI or ESG expertise required. We handle all technical work and interpretation.

Timeline: Weeks to Months (flexible, at your convenience, no commitment, withdraw anytime)

2. Accounting Advisor & Practitioner Feedback

For: Accountants, ESG Advisors, Sustainability Practitioners

What you get:

- Insight into AI capabilities and limitations for your advisory work
- Research findings on SME ESG reporting barriers and opportunities
- Co-authorship opportunities on case studies and policy briefs
- Positioning as thought leader on practitioner perspectives in AI and ESG

What you provide:

- **Pre-implementation interview:** Current practices, challenges, barriers (30 minutes)
    - What gaps do you see with SME clients?
    - Where do you spend most advisory time?
    - What would help advisors work more effectively with SMEs?
- **Post-implementation interview:** Experience working with AI reports provided by the research (30 minutes)
    - How well do the AI reports serve as starting points for advisory work?
    - What value do advisors add beyond AI generation?
    - What framework challenges do your clients face?
- **Optional feedback:** Review preliminary findings and shape research implications (email feedback, 1-2 hours total)

Participation is entirely voluntary. You can withdraw at any time without further commitment.

Timeline: Weeks to Months (flexible scheduling)

3. Independent Practitioner Evaluation Study

For: Accountants, ESG Advisors, Sustainability Practitioners, Policy Professionals

What you get:

- Compensation for the evaluation work
- Contribute to peer-reviewed academic research on AI and ESG quality
- Help validate what makes ESG reports credible in professional practice

What you do:

- Review and rate 10-12 ESG report excerpts (both AI-generated and manual) on quality dimensions

- **Blind evaluation:** You won't know which reports are AI-generated vs. manual, ensuring unbiased professional judgment
- Results inform policy recommendations to regulatory bodies

Timing: You choose when to participate

4. Policy & Regulatory Engagement

For: Policy Teams, Professional Bodies (ACCA, ICAEW, etc.), Regulatory Stakeholders

What we're seeking:

- Input on research direction and policy-relevant findings
- Feedback on regulatory implications and recommendations
- Collaboration on co-authored policy briefs
- Opportunities to present findings to regulatory audiences

What we offer:

- **Evidence-based research** on SME ESG reporting barriers and AI's role
- **Policy-ready insights** on proportionate disclosure standards, framework harmonization, and regulatory implementation
- **Co-authorship opportunities** positioning your organization as thought leader
- **Stakeholder input session** workshop to validate findings and discuss policy implications
- **Customized policy briefs** addressing your specific regulatory or standards focus

No commercial endorsement or product liability. This is research collaboration, not vendor support.

Timeline: Weeks to Months (flexible engagement)

5. Co-Authored Publications

For: Academics, Research Institutions, Professional Organizations

Collaboration opportunities:

1. **Co-Authored Case Studies**
2. **Co-Authored Research Brief**
3. **Co-Authored Academic Research Paper**

Contribution levels:

- **Light:** Provide feedback on draft findings (email)
- **Medium:** Co-author case study or brief

- **Deep:** Full co-authorship with author meetings and writing collaboration on Academic Research Paper

Research Ethics & Participant Rights

All activities covered under University of Nottingham ethics approval

Your rights:

- Withdraw at any time without further commitment or explanation
- Request anonymity in publications (data anonymized regardless), except for co-author names and acknowledgements agreed
- Review findings and drafts before publication
- Decline future participation without further commitment or explanation

Data handling:

- Anonymized in all publications
- Stored securely on University of Nottingham secure servers
- Commercial information aggregated and anonymized

Research Outputs You Can Expect

1. **Co-authored case studies** on how advisors support SME ESG adoption
2. **Evidence-based policy brief** informing regulatory recommendations
3. **Academic research paper** on practitioner roles in AI-assisted reporting
4. **Practitioner evaluation study** validating report quality across dimensions
5. **Research briefs & infographics** accessible to practitioners

Value to Your Organization

For SMEs:

- Free professional-quality ESG reports
- Understanding of your current disclosure capacity
- Data-driven insights on framework requirements
- Minimal time investment

For Advisors & Practitioners:

- Empirical evidence on where AI adds value and where professional judgment is essential
- Thought leadership positioning on AI and ESG
- Co-authored publications strengthening professional credibility

- Policy influence on future SME disclosure standards

For Policy Organizations:

- Research-driven evidence on SME ESG reporting barriers
- Practitioner insights on proportionate disclosure implementation
- Policy recommendations grounded in real-world experience
- Thought leadership and stakeholder credibility

For All Participants:

- Contribution to evidence-based policy and professional standards
- Access to research findings and deliverables
- Ethical research partnership (no commercial pressure or endorsements)
- Network with peers and researchers advancing SME sustainability

FAQ

Q: Will my company data be shared?
A: No. All data remains private. Reports generated for your company are yours alone. Only anonymized, aggregated findings are published.

Q: Do I need ESG expertise?
A: Not for SME participants. For advisor feedback or evaluator roles, yes.

Q: Can I withdraw?
A: Yes, at any time, without commitment or explanation required. No financial cost required.

Q: Is there a cost?
A: No. Research is funded by the British Academy Fellowship. Evaluator participants are compensated via Prolific.

Q: When do you need an answer?
A: Flexible. Get in touch anytime. Late enquiries may still be accommodated depending on phase.

Q: Can my organization be named as a research partner?
A: Yes, if you're involved. We always ask first.

Getting Started

Interested in participating? Contact:

Dr Huamao Wang
Associate Professor in Finance, Risk and Banking

Nottingham University Business School
University of Nottingham

📧 **Email:** huamao.wang@nottingham.ac.uk
🔗 **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/huamao-wang

In your message, please mention:

1. Your organization/role
2. Which participation option(s) interest(s) you (SME, advisor feedback, evaluator, policy engagement, co-authorship)
3. Any questions or constraints on timing